

Exegesis——self-directed creative project responding to Remaking Worlds

1. Introduction

Humans have long relied on myths, beliefs, and religions to understand their existence and place in the world, shaping culture and identity. Reflecting on the course's focus on *Reconstituting and Recalling: Myth, Religion, Belief in the Anthropocene*, I realized that the communication of myths across cultures and their influence on human ideas about nature and existence aligns with my project's goals.

My motivation for this project is twofold: to deepen my understanding of the course content and enhance my creative thinking and practical skills. I aim to explore how different mythologies intersect and influence each other, sparking greater interest in cross-cultural mythology among the audience.

This project is not just an academic requirement, but a unique opportunity to apply my knowledge creatively. After considering various formats, I decided to create a podcast. The podcast will feature a dialogue about gods, offering an immersive exploration of mythological narratives from different cultures. Through this approach, I hope to foster a deeper understanding of mythology and its cultural relevance.

2. Fundamental concept

This podcast project explores the concept of "God" as a cultural, philosophical, and psychological construct across various civilizations. Through a series of dialogues, it examines how divine narratives shape human identity, collective values, and the ongoing search for meaning, bridging ancient mythologies with contemporary life.

The core idea is to select three deities from different Asian countries and invite them as fictionalized guests to narrate the myths of their respective cultures. Each deity will speak in the first person, offering an intimate and immersive storytelling experience. As the host, I will guide the conversations, posing questions to the gods, comparing their stories, and analyzing the connections between them. This approach fosters a deeper understanding of the cultural and philosophical significance of these divine figures. Drawing inspiration from my passion for mythology and the course material, this project aims to engage the audience in a reflective exploration of how these ancient narratives continue to resonate today. By combining the timeless nature of myth with the modern podcast format, the project provides a unique platform for listeners to appreciate the enduring relevance of divine stories across different cultures. In the process, the podcast invites both personal reflection and cross-cultural comparison, offering valuable insights into the ways that mythological traditions shape our perceptions of the divine and the human condition.

3. Creative experimentation and process

The inspiration for this project stems from two primary sources. First, the decision to adopt the podcast format is influenced by my personal habit of regularly listening to podcasts. I appreciate the immersive atmosphere they create and the manner in which hosts and guests engage in deep, reflective conversations from their own perspectives. I regard this as a form of pure and authentic communication, which I hoped to replicate in my own project. Second, the content itself is closely linked to both the themes explored in the course and my long-standing passion for mythology. A

particularly significant source of information and theoretical grounding for this project was the book *The Mythology of All Races*, which provided a rich foundation for my exploration of cross-cultural divine narratives.

Overall, this project reflects both my personal interests and creative preferences, in terms of both theme and format. As a result, I found the process deeply enjoyable and fulfilling, and it has significantly enhanced my understanding of the course material as well as my skills in creative thinking and content production.

Of course, I also faced many challenges during the process. For instance, I initially wasn't sure whether my content and format would work, and I originally intended to create a video rather than a podcast. I had a lot of uncertainty about my theme and content. To clarify my thoughts, I discussed them with my classmates during lessons and consulted Instructor Tania. Tania asked me if I had ever made a video before, and honestly, I hadn't. She expressed her support for my idea but reminded me that time was running short, advising me to manage my time wisely. I found her advice to be very reasonable. After considering the content I had referenced and reflecting on her suggestions, I ultimately decided to go ahead with creating a podcast instead of a video.

I also recognize that there are many areas where I could have done better and where improvement is needed. Originally, I planned to have different friends voice the characters for my podcast, using distinct voices to differentiate the gods. However, due to the limited time during finals and my friends' busy schedules, I ultimately decided to record the host's part myself and use AI to read the remaining characters.

Additionally, when selecting the opening music, I overlooked the issue of copyright, which meant that the music I had carefully chosen could not be used. As a result, I had to spend extra time finding royalty-free music, which caused some time loss and delays in the project.

4. Significance of the Work

I believe the significance of my work is multifaceted. Academically, it serves two purposes: it complements and expands upon the course content by offering a unique perspective on the comparative study of cross-cultural mythology, and it integrates academic theory with creative practice, demonstrating interdisciplinary knowledge while exploring the cultural impact of mythology.

Culturally, this work emphasizes the importance of cross-cultural exchange in understanding different cultures' roots. It shows how these mythological narratives can help modern individuals better understand their heritage, while promoting acceptance and inclusivity. In today's globalized world, the project serves as a reminder of the shared human experience and the value of diversity.

On a personal level, this project has enhanced my skills in creative thinking, content creation, and audio production. Seeing my work broadcast during the final exhibition fills me with pride and joy, knowing that it has contributed to the conversation about mythology and culture. This project has been a rewarding academic and personal achievement.

Finally, when writing this article, I haven't shared any content from my podcast with others yet. I plan to gather audience feedback during the live exhibition and look forward to hearing their thoughts.

5. Main References, Literature, and Theoretical Support

Adarsh Prajapati, 2024, 'Brahma: The Creator God in Hinduism – Mythology, Worship, and Spiritual Significance', *Hinduism*, December 21, 2024, accessed 26 April 2025, <https://hinduism.com/brahma-the-creator-god-in-hinduism/?utm_source>.

Alexander, H.B., 1920. *The mythology of all races*.

Allan, S., 1991. *The shape of the turtle: myth, art, and cosmos in early China*. State University of New York Press.

Kasulis, T.P., 2004. *Shinto: The way home*. University of Hawaii Press.

Maia Hadaway, '2024, The Role of Brahma in the Creation of the Universe: Insights from the Puranas', *Hindu Mythology*, October 21 2024, accessed 26 April 2025, <https://hindu.mythologyworldwide.com/the-role-of-brahma-in-the-creation-of-the-universe-insights-from-the-puranas/?utm_source>.

6. Appendix

Podcast Transcript

Podcast name: Dialogue of the Gods

time duration: About 6min (About 1000 words)

Main Cast: Compere (Me, Basitia), Brahma, Nvwa, Amaterasu

【Opening BGM】

Compere 1

Welcome, dear listeners, to a realm beyond time—where myths breathe, and the divine walk among us. Tonight, we gather voices from across cultures and cosmos. Our guests today are mainly from the East. Now, they speak—not through scriptures, but in their own words. Let us begin... with the gods themselves. So would Brahma begin firstly? Introduce yourself and tell the listeners what do you represent for?

Brahma 1 (Gentle and wise, like an old sage):

Of course! Hi everyone, I'm Brahma From India—the creator in Hindu mythology. Before anything existed, I imagined the universe and shaped order out of chaos. I have four faces to see in all directions, and they represent the four Vedas—ancient wisdom. Not many people know me well, and that's okay—after creation, I kind of stepped back. [chuckles] But without me, there'd be no first light... and no you, sitting here listening to our stories (Prajapati, 2024).

Nvwa 1(Gentle, warm, like a nurturing elder):

Hello, I'm Nüwa from China—goddess of creation in Chinese mythology. They say I shaped the first humans from clay, one by one, with care and love. When the sky cracked and floods came, I didn't run. I melted five-colored stones and mended the heavens. I'm not just a creator—I'm a healer, a protector, a mother to the world. Even today, I stand for resilience and the power of gentle strength(Alexander, 1920).

Amaterasu 1(Graceful, radiant, with quiet strength):

Greetings. I am Amaterasu from Japan—the goddess of the sun, light, and life in Japanese mythology. When I shine, the world awakens; when I retreat, shadows fall. Long ago, I once hid myself away, and the world plunged into darkness... until laughter and a mirror called me back. I bring warmth, order, and the rhythm of day and night. And through my light, the spirit of harmony lives on.

Compere 2

Amazing! Thank you all so much, and once again, welcome to be a guest of our podcast, everyone. Today, we're diving into a fascinating topic: Universal Themes in Nature Across Mythologies. So, as gods yourselves, what do you think that Rooted in nature, what kinds of stories do Chinese myths have to tell?

Nvwa 2

Earth, wind, thunder, lightning, water, and fire—in Chinese mythology, these aren't just settings. They're living characters, divine beings, and mirrors of human emotion and order. Mending the sky isn't just about fixing a disaster—it's about harmony between humans and nature. My college Kuafu chasing the sun? A bold challenge to nature's limits—and a symbol of our longing for light (Alexander, 1920).

Compere 3

We've seen how nature comes alive in Chinese myths—shaping gods, guiding values, and reflecting deep truths about the human condition. But China isn't alone in this. Across the Himalayas, Indian mythology offers a whole other world where nature is not just powerful—it's sacred. So next, let's journey into the Japan myths.

Amaterasu 2

Well..... I'm Amaterasu and the Sun Goddess. Once, I hid in a cave, and the world fell into darkness. But when I returned, light, life, and order were restored. Every day, my light dispels the darkness, restoring balance and harmony to the world. It's a reminder that we depend on the cycles of nature—like day and night—to sustain us. Through my story, I hope you'll feel the power of balance and harmony in your own life.

Compere 4

Excellent! How about Brahma?

Brahma 2

I'm Brahma, the creator of the universe. My role is to bring order from chaos, shaping the world around us. Everything, from the mountains to the smallest creatures, is part of the plan I set in motion. Through my four faces, I watch over the four corners of the world, guiding nature's cycles and the balance of life. My story reflects how creation and change are interconnected—just like the natural world, where every end brings a new beginning. I remind you that from chaos comes order, and from that order, life evolves (Hadaway, 2024).

Compere 5

Yeah, thanks all of you! I find that Brahma and Amaterasu both focus on maintaining balance in nature—Brahma through overseeing creation, and Amaterasu through the cycle of light and darkness. Their stories show how order emerges from chaos. Brahma creates the universe, while Amaterasu's return brings light back to the world.

Nvwa 3

And there are some difference, too. Brahma's view is cosmic, about the whole universe, while Amaterasu's is more about daily cycles, like light and darkness. In Chinese mythology, the relationship between humans and nature is more direct, where gods and elements reflect human challenges, whereas Brahma and Amaterasu focus on divine control over nature's laws(Allan, 1991).

Compere 6

Yes! Thank you, I completely agree! Do you think these perspectives influence modern culture in your countries?

Amaterasu 3

My story has shaped traditions like New Year celebrations and festivals honoring the sun, where people celebrate the return of light. The idea of restoring balance is key in Japan, especially after natural disasters, focusing on order and harmony.

I also represent unity and collective effort, values that are central in modern Japan. Through my story, Japanese culture celebrates life's cycles, the seasons, and the bond between humans and nature(Kasulis, 2004)

Brahma 3

My story has deeply influenced modern Indian culture, especially in how creation, balance, and change are understood. As the creator of the universe, I bring order from chaos, which aligns with India's belief in the inter-connectedness of the cosmos and life cycles. The idea that every ending brings a new beginning reflects the Hindu concepts of samsara (life, death, and rebirth) and karma, emphasizing how actions shape the future.

Nvwa 4

Oh! That's sounds so amazing!

Compere 7

I couldn't agree more, thank you all for your wonderful insights! I've learned so much from what you've shared, and I'm sure our listeners feel the same! Now, it's time for a quick commercial break. Stay tuned, because after the break, we've got even more exciting content coming your way...

【Ending BGM】